

0.0.1 Foremost Knowledge

aggaññasuttam

1. Thus was heard by me. On one occasion the Auspicious One was dwelling in Savatthi at the Eastern Monastery, the mansion of Migara's Mother. At that time Vasettha and Bharadvaja were living on probation among the bhikkhus, wishing to become bhikkhus. Then in the evening, the Auspicious One, having emerged from seclusion, having descended from the palace, was walking up and down in the open air in the shade of the palace. Vasettha saw that the Auspicious One, having emerged from seclusion, having descended from the palace, was walking up and down in the open air in the shade of the palace. Having seen, he address Bharadvaja: "This Auspicious One, O friend Bharadvaja, having emerged from seclusion, having descended from the palace, is walking up and down in the open air in the shade of the palace. Let us approach this Auspicious One, O friend Bharadvaja. Hopefully, we might gain the hearing of a Dhamma talk in the presence of the Auspicious One." "Yes, friend," Bharadvaja replied to Vasettha. So then Vasettha and Bharadvaja approached the Auspicious One. Having approached, having bowed down to the Auspicious One, they walk back and forth following the Auspicious One.

evam me sutam: ekam samayam bhagava savatthiyam viharati pubbarame migaramatupasade. tena kho pana samayena vasetthabharadvaja bhik-

khūsu parivasanti¹ bhikkhubhāvaṃ ākaṅkhamānā.
 atha kho bhagavā sāyaṇhasamayam paṭisallānā
 vuṭṭhito pāsādā orohitvā pāsādapacchāyāyaṃ² ab-
 bhokāse caṅkamati. addasā kho vāseṭṭho bhaga-
 vantam sāyaṇhasamayam paṭisallānā vuṭṭhitam
 pāsādā orohitvā pāsādapacchāyāyaṃ abbhokāse
 caṅkamantam. disvāna bhāradvājaṃ āmantesi:
 “ayaṃ āvuso bhāradvāja bhagavā sāyaṇhasama-
 yaṃ paṭisallānā vuṭṭhito pāsādā orohitvā pāsāda-
 pacchāyāyaṃ abbhokāse caṅkamati. āyāmāvuso
 bhāradvāja yena bhagavā tenupasaṅkamissāma.
 appevanāma labheyyāma bhagavato santikā³ dham-
 miṃ katham savaṇāyā”ti. ‘evamāvuso’ti kho bhā-
 radvājo vāseṭṭhassa paccassosi. atha kho vāseṭ-
 ṭhabhāradvājā yena bhagavā tenupasaṅkamimsu.
 upasaṅkamitvā bhagavantam abhivādetvā bhaga-
 vantam caṅkamantam anucaṅkamimsu.

2. Then the Auspicious One addressed Vasettha: “Here Vasettha, being brahmin by birth, of a brahmin caste, you have gone forth from the home life into homelessness from a brahmin family. Hopefully, O Vasettha, the brahmins do not abuse you with verbal abuse.” “Certainly, O Bhante, the brahmins fully abuse and insult us with personally suitable verbal abuse without holding back.”

atha kho bhagavā vāseṭṭham āmantesi: ‘tumhe khvattha vāseṭṭhā, brāhmaṇajaccā brāhmaṇaku-
 līnā brāhmaṇakulā agārasmā anagāriyaṃ pabba-

jitā. kacci vo vāseṭṭhā, brāhmaṇā na akkosanti na paribhāsanti?ti. “taggha no bhante, brāhmaṇā akkosanti paribhāsanti attarūpāya paribhāsāya paripuṇṇāya no aparipuṇṇāyā?ti”.

3. “But in which way, O Vasettha, do the brahmins fully abuse and insult you with personally suitable verbal abuse without holding back?” “The brahmins, O Bhante, say thus: “The brahmins are the only most excellent caste, other castes are inferior. The brahmins are the only bright caste, other castes are dark. The brahmins are the only well-born, not non-brahmins. The brahmins are the only legitimate sons of Brahma, born of his mouth, born of Brahma, created by Brahma, an heir of Brahma. You, having abandoned the most excellent caste, have entered into an inferior caste, that of the shaven-headed counterfeit samanas, those dark menial offsprings of our kinsmen’s feet. This is not good, this is not proper, that you, having abandoned the most excellent caste, have entered into an inferior caste, that of the shaven-headed counterfeit samanas, those dark menial offsprings of our kinsmen’s feet.” Thus do the brahmins fully abuse and insult us with personally suitable verbal abuse without holding back?”

“yathā katham pana vo vāseṭṭhā, brāhmaṇā akkosanti paribhāsanti attarūpāya paribhāsāya paripuṇṇāya no aparipuṇṇāyā?ti”. brāhmaṇā bhante evamāhaṃsu: “brāhmaṇo’va seṭṭho vaṇṇo hīnā

aññe vaṇṇā brāhmaṇo'va sukko vaṇṇo, kaṇhā aññe vaṇṇā¹. brāhmaṇā'va sujjhanti no abrāhmaṇā brāhmaṇā'va brahmuno puttā orasā mukhato jātā brahmajā brahmanimmitā brahmadāyādā. te tumhe seṭṭhaṃ vaṇṇaṃ hitvā hīnamattha vaṇṇaṃ ajjhupagatā, yadidaṃ muṇḍake samaṇake ibbhe kaṇhe bandhupādāpacce. tayidaṃ na sādhu, tayidaṃ nappatirūpaṃ, yaṃ tumhe seṭṭhaṃ vaṇṇaṃ hitvā hīnamattha vaṇṇaṃ ajjhupagatā, yadidaṃ muṇḍake samaṇake ibbhe kaṇhe bandhupādāpacce”ti. evaṃ kho no bhante brāhmaṇā akkosanti paribhāsanti attarūpāya paribhāsāya paripuṇṇāya no aparipuṇṇāyā”ti.

4. Certainly, O Vasettha, the brahmins do not remember their ancestry when they say thus to you: “The brahmins are the only most excellent caste, other castes are inferior. The brahmins are the only bright caste, other castes are dark. The brahmins are the only well-born, not non-brahmins. The brahmins are the only legitimate sons of Brahma, born of his mouth, born of Brahma, created by Brahma, an heir of Brahma.” Yet, O Vasettha, for the brahmins, the brahmin women are also seen menstruating, also being pregnant, also giving birth, also breastfeeding. Yet those brahmins, evidently being born from womb, say thus: The brahmins are the only most excellent caste, other castes are inferior. The brahmins are the only bright caste, other castes are dark. The brahmins are the only well-born, not non-brahmins. The

brahmins are the only legitimate sons of Brahma, born of his mouth, born of Brahma, created by Brahma, an heir of Brahma.” Those brahmins simply misrepresent Brahma with untrue statements and accumulate much demerit.

“taggha vo vāsetṭhā brāhmaṇā porāṇaṃ asarantā evamāhaṃsu: brāhmaṇo’va seṭṭho vaṇṇo, hīnā aññe vaṇṇā. brāhmaṇo va sukko vaṇṇo, kaṇhā aññe vaṇṇā, brāhmaṇā’va sujjhanti no abrahmaṇā, brāhmaṇā’va brahmuno puttā orasā mukhato jātā brāhmajā brahmanimmitā brahmadāyādā”ti. dissanti kho pana vāsetṭhā brāhmaṇānaṃ brāhmaṇiyo utuniyo’pi gabbhiniyo’pi vijāyamānā’pi pāyamānā’pi. te ca brāhmaṇā yonijā’va samānā evamāhaṃsu: brāhmaṇo’va seṭṭho vaṇṇo -pe- puttā orasā -pe- brahmadāyādā”ti. te ca brahmāṇaṇceva abbhācikkhanti musā ca bhāsanti bahuñca apuññaṃ pasavanti.

5. There are, O Vasettha, these four castes, the Khattiya, the Brahmin, the Vessa and the Sudda. Here, O Vasettha, a certain khattiya is a killer of living beings, a taker of what is not given, an engager in misconduct in sensual pleasures, a speaker of falsehood, a speaker of divisive speech, a speaker of harsh speech, a covetous one, one with a mind of ill-will, a holder of wrong view. Thus, O Vasettha, these dhammas which are unwholesome and reckoned as unwholesome, blameworthy and reckoned

as blameworthy, not to be associated with and reckoned as not to be associated with, unsuitable for the noble ones and reckoned as unsuitable for the noble ones, dark with dark results, blamed by the wise, a khattiya is seen engaging in them. Here, O Vasettha, a certain brahmin too is a killer of living beings, a taker of what is not given, an engager in misconduct in sensual pleasures, a speaker of falsehood, a speaker of divisive speech, a speaker of harsh speech, a covetous one, one with a mind of ill-will, a holder of wrong view. Thus, O Vasettha, these dhammas which are unwholesome and reckoned as unwholesome, blameworthy and reckoned as blameworthy, not to be associated with and reckoned as not to be associated with, unsuitable for the noble ones and reckoned as unsuitable for the noble ones, dark with dark results, blamed by the wise, a brahmin too is seen engaging in them. Here, O Vasettha, a certain vessa too is a killer of living beings, a taker of what is not given, an engager in misconduct in sensual pleasures, a speaker of falsehood, a speaker of divisive speech, a speaker of harsh speech, a covetous one, one with a mind of ill-will, a holder of wrong view. Thus, O Vasettha, these dhammas which are unwholesome and reckoned as unwholesome, blameworthy and reckoned as blameworthy, not to be associated with and reckoned as not to be associated with, unsuitable for the noble ones and reckoned as unsuitable for the noble ones, dark with dark results, blamed by the wise, a vessa too is seen engaging in them. Here, O Vasettha, a certain sudda too is a killer of living beings, a taker of what is not given, an engager in misconduct

in sensual pleasures, a speaker of falsehood, a speaker of divisive speech, a speaker of harsh speech, a covetous one, one with a mind of ill-will, a holder of wrong view. Thus, O Vasettha, these dhammas which are unwholesome and reckoned as unwholesome, blameworthy and reckoned as blameworthy, not to be associated with and reckoned as not to be associated with, unsuitable for the noble ones and reckoned as unsuitable for the noble ones, dark with dark results, blamed by the wise, a sudda too is seen engaging in them.

cattāro' me vāsetṭha vaṇṇā, khattiyā brāhmaṇā vessā suddā. khattiyo'pi kho vāsetṭhā, idhekacco paṇātipātī hoti adinnādāyī kāmesu micchācārī mu-sāvādī pisuṇavāco pharusavāco samphappalāpī abhiññhālu byāpannacitto micchādiṭṭhī. iti kho vāsetṭha, ye' me dhammā akusalā akusalasaṅkhātā sāvajjā sāvajjasāṅkhātā asevitabbā asevitabbasaṅkhātā na alamariyā na alamariyasāṅkhātā, kaṇhā kaṇhavipākā viññugarahitā, khattiye pi te idhekacce sandissanti. brāhmaṇo pi kho vāsetṭha -pe- vesso pi kho vāsetṭha -pe- suddo pi kho vāsetṭha idhekacco paṇātipātī hoti adinnādāyī -pe- micchādiṭṭhī. iti kho vāsetṭha, ye' me dhammā akusalā akusalasaṅkhātā -pe- kaṇhā kaṇhavipākā viññugarahitā, sudde pi te idhekacce sandissanti.

6. Here, O Vasettha, a certain khattiya is an abstainer from the killing of living beings, an abstainer from the

taking of what is not given, an abstainer from misconduct in sensual pleasures, an abstainer from false speech, an abstainer from divisive speech, an abstainer from harsh speech, an abstainer from senseless prattle, not covetous, one of a benevolent mind, one of right view. Thus, O Vasettha, these dhammas which are wholesome and reckoned as wholesome, blameless and reckoned as blameless, to be associated with and reckoned as to be associated with, suitable for the noble ones and reckoned as suitable for the noble ones. bright with bright results, praised by the wise, a khattiya is seen engaging in them. Here, O Vasettha, a certain brahmin too is an abstainer from the killing of living beings, an abstainer from the taking of what is not given, an abstainer from misconduct in sensual pleasures, an abstainer from false speech, an abstainer from divisive speech, an abstainer from harsh speech, an abstainer from senseless prattle, not covetous, one of a benevolent mind, one of right view. Thus, O Vasettha, these dhammas which are wholesome and reckoned as wholesome, blameless and reckoned as blameless, to be associated with and reckoned as to be associated with, suitable for the noble ones and reckoned as suitable for the noble ones, bright with bright results, praised by the wise, a brahmin is seen engaging in them. Here, O Vasettha, a certain vessa too is an abstainer from the killing of living beings, an abstainer from the taking of what is not given, an abstainer from misconduct in sensual pleasures, an abstainer from false speech, an abstainer from divisive speech, an abstainer from harsh speech, an abstainer from senseless prattle,

not covetous, one of a benevolent mind, one of right view. Thus, O Vasettha, these dhammas which are wholesome and reckoned as wholesome, blameless and reckoned as blameless, to be associated with and reckoned as to be associated with, suitable for the noble ones and reckoned as suitable for the noble ones, bright with bright results, praised by the wise, a vessa is seen engaging in them. Here, O Vasettha, a certain sudda too is an abstainer from the killing of living beings, an abstainer from the taking of what is not given, an abstainer from misconduct in sensual pleasures, an abstainer from false speech, an abstainer from divisive speech, an abstainer from harsh speech, an abstainer from senseless prattle, not covetous, one of a benevolent mind, one of right view. Thus, O Vasettha, these dhammas which are wholesome and reckoned as wholesome, blameless and reckoned as blameless, to be associated with and reckoned as to be associated with, suitable for the noble ones and reckoned as suitable for the noble ones, bright with bright results, praised by the wise, a sudda is seen engaging in them.

khattiyo pi kho vāsetṭha, idhekacco paṇātipātā paṭivirato hoti. adinnādānā paṭivirato, kāmesu micchācārā paṭivirato, musāvādā paṭivirato, pi-sunāya vācāya paṭivirato, pharusāya vācāya paṭivirato, samphappalāpā paṭivirato, anabhijjhālu abyāpannacitto sammādiṭṭhi. iti kho vāsetṭhā, ye' me dhammā kusalā kusalasāṅkhātā anavajjā anavajjasāṅkhātā sevitabbā sevitabbasāṅkhātā alamarīyā alamariyasāṅkhātā sukkā sukkavipākā viñ-

ñuppasatthā, khattiye pi te vāseṭṭhā idhekacce sandissanti. brāhmaṇo pi kho vāseṭṭhā, -pe- vesso pi kho vāseṭṭhā -pe- suddo pi kho vāseṭṭhā idhekacco pāṇātipātā paṭivirato hoti -pe- anabhijjhālu abyāpannacitto sammādiṭṭhi. iti kho vāseṭṭhā, ye’me dhammā kusalā kusalasaṅkhātā anavajjā anavajjasaṅkhātā sevitabbā sevitabbasaṅkhātā alamariyā alamariyasaṅkhātā sukkā sukkavipākā viññuppasatthā,¹ suddepi te idhekacce sandissanti.

7. With both dark and bright dhammas existing thus, O Vasettha, both-ways mixed among these four castes, [both what is] blamed by the wise and praised by the wise, of which here the brahmins say thus: “The brahmins are the only most excellent caste, other castes are inferior. The brahmins are the only bright caste, other castes are dark. The brahmins are the only well-born, not non-brahmins. The brahmins are the only legitimate sons of Brahma, born of his mouth, born of Brahma, created by Brahma, an heir of Brahma.” that the wise do not agree. What is the reason for that? Because, O Vasettha, whichever bhikkhu of the four castes is an arahant with asavas extincted, one who has lived [the life of purity], done what must be done, laid down the burden, attained the true advantage, completely extincted the fetters of being, one who is liberated by right final knowledge, he is said to be the foremost of them according to Dhamma, not non-Dhamma. Indeed Dhamma, O Vasetthā, is simply the best cause of birth in this world and the next.

imesu kho vāseṭṭhā, catusu vaṇṇesu evaṃ ubhaya-
 vokiṇṇesu vattamānesu kaṇhasukkesu dhammesu
 viññugarahitesu ceva viññuppasatthesu ca. ya-
 dettha brāhmaṇā evamāhaṃsu: brāhmaṇo'va seṭ-
 ṭho vaṇṇo hīnā aññe vaṇṇā. brāhmaṇo'va sukko
 vaṇṇo kaṇhā aññe vaṇṇā, brāhmaṇā'va sujjhanti
 no abrāhmaṇā, brāhmaṇā'va brahmuno puttā orasā
 mukhato jātā brahmajā brahmanimmitā brahma-
 dāyādā"ti. taṃ tesam viññū nānujānanti. taṃ
 kissa hetu? imesaṃ hi vāseṭṭhā, catunnam vaṇ-
 ṇānam yo hoti bhikkhu araham khīṇāsavo vusi-
 tavā katakaraṇīyo ohitabhāro anuppattasadattho
 parikkhīṇabhavasamyojano sammadaññāvimutto,
 so nesaṃ² aggamakkhāyati. dhammeneva no adham-
 mena. dhammo hi vāseṭṭhā seṭṭho janetasmiṃ
 diṭṭhe ceva dhamme abhisamparāyeca³.

8. By this method, O Vasettha, it is to be known how the Dhamma is simply the best cause of birth in this world and the next. King Pasenadi of Kosala knows well, O Vasettha: "The samana Gotama who has gone forth from a Sakyan family, is superior." But the Sakyans, O vāseṭṭhā, exist as subordinate followers of King Pasenadi of Kosala. They, the Sakyans, O Vasettha, perform acts of submission to King Pasenadi of Kosala, bowing down, rising from their seats [as a token of respect], doing reverential salutations and paying homage. Thus, O Vasettha, those acts of submission which they, the Sakyans, perform to King Pasenadi of Kosala, bowing down, rising

from their seats [as a token of respect], doing reverential salutations and paying homage, it is those [same acts] that King Pasenadi of Kosala, perform towards the Tathagata, bowing down, rising from his seat [as a token of respect], doing reverential salutations and paying homage, [thinking]: “Certainly the samana Gotama is well-born, while I am ill-born, the samana Gotama is powerful, while I am powerless, the samana Gotama is elegant, while I am ugly, the samana Gotama is of great influence, while I am of little influence.” Now for him it is only by honoring the Dhamma, respecting the Dhamma, revering the Dhamma, worshipping the Dhamma, esteeming the Dhamma, that King Pasenadi of Kosala, perform such acts of submission towards the Tathagata, bowing down, rising from his seat [as a token of respect], doing reverential salutations and paying homage.

tadamināpetam vāseṭṭhā, pariyāyena veditabbam yathā dhammova seṭṭho janetasmim diṭṭhe ceva dhamme abhisamparāye¹ca. jānāti kho pana vāseṭṭhā, rājā pasenadi kosalo “samaṇo gotamo anuttaro sakyakulā pabbajito”ti. sakyā kho pana vāseṭṭhā, rañño pasenadino kosalassa anantarā anuyuttā bhavanti. karonti kho vāseṭṭhā, sakyā raññe pasenadimhi kosale nipaccakāraṃ abhivādanam paccuṭṭhānaṃ añjalikammaṃ sāmīcikkammaṃ. iti kho vāseṭṭhā, yaṃ karonti sakyā raññe pasenadimhi kosale nipaccakāraṃ abhivādanam paccuṭṭhānaṃ añjalikammaṃ sāmīcikkammaṃ, karoti taṃ rājā pasenadi kosalo tathāgate nipaccakāraṃ abhi-

vādanam paccutṭhānam añjalikammaṃ sāmīcika-
 maṃ. nanu² ‘sujāto samaṇo gotamo, dujjāto³’ha-
 masmi, balavā samaṇo gotamo dubbalo’hamasmi,
 pāsādiko samaṇo gotamo dubbaṇṇo’hamasmi, ma-
 hesakkho samaṇo gotamo, appesakkho’hamasmi”ti.
 atha kho naṃ dhammaṃ yeva sakkaronto dham-
 maṃ garukaronto dhammaṃ mānento dhammaṃ
 pūjento dhammaṃ apacāyamāno evaṃ rājā pase-
 nadi kosalo tathāgate nipaccakāraṃ karoti abhi-
 vādanam paccutṭhānam añjalikammaṃ sāmīcika-
 maṃ.

9. By this method too, O Vasettha, it is to be known how the Dhamma is simply the best cause of birth in this world and the next. All of you here, O Vasettha, of various births, various names, various lineages, various families, have gone forth from home life into homelessness. When being asked: “Who are you?” you should acknowledge: “We are samanas, sons of the Sakyan.” Of whom, O Vasettha, faith in the Tathagata is settled, rooted, established, firm, unshakeable by any samana or brahmana or deva or mara or Brahma or anyone in the world, this is fitting for him to say: “I am truly the legitimate son of the Auspicious One, born of his mouth, born of the Dhamma, created by the Dhamma, an heir of the Dhamma.” What is the reason for that? Because, O Vasettha, this is the designation for the Tathagata: “An embodiment of Dhamma.” Also “An embodiment of Brahma.” Also “A Dhamma Being.” Also “A Brahma

Being.”

iminā’pi kho etaṃ vāseṭṭhā, pariyāyena veditabbaṃ yathā dhammo’va seṭṭho jane’tasmiṃ diṭṭhe ceva dhamme abhisamparāye¹ca. tumhe khvathā vāseṭṭhā nānājaccā nānānāmā nānāgottā nānākulā agārasmā anagāriyaṃ pabbajitā. ‘ke tumhe?’ti puṭṭhā samānā, ‘samaṇā sakyaputtiyamhā’ti paṭijānātha. yassa kho panassa vāseṭṭhā, tathāgate saddhā nivīṭṭhā mūlajātā paṭiṭṭhitā daḥhā asaṃhāriyā⁴ samaṇena vā brāhmaṇena vā devena vā mārena vā brahmunā vā kenaci vā lokasmiṃ, tassetāṃ kallaṃ vacanāya: bhagavato’mhi putto oraso mukhato jāto dhammajo dhammanimmito dhammadāyādo’ti. taṃ kissa hetu? tathāgatassa he-
taṃ vāseṭṭhā adhivacanaṃ dhammakāyo iti pi, brahmakāyo iti pi, dhammabhūto iti pi, brahmabhūto iti pi.

